currents of history. An absorbing but difficult tour in Sri Lanka was an invaluable politico-military experience. But, if there was one great learning, that was in a China that I caught at an inflection point in 2009. As Ambassador there, subsequently in the US, and then as Foreign Secretary, I have had a ringside view of recent global changes. Above all, interacting with our own leadership over many years at different levels of hierarchy had a value that is difficult to put in words. From that, the big takeaways were the importance of defining strategic goals, recognizing optimal outcomes and appreciating the interplay of politics and policy.

This book was developed in the course of the last two years through a series of events. Lectures given at think tanks, conferences or business forums form its core. They remain relevant in large measure but have been updated where required. ‘The Lessons of Awadh’ is a fusion of comments on various such occasions. ‘The Art of the Disruption’ draws on addresses to the Oslo Energy Forum, the Raisina Dialogue, the Sir Bani Yas Forum and the Centre for Strategic and International Studies. ‘Krishna’s Choice’ was articulated in its essence at the Sai Foundation, New Delhi. ‘The Dogmas of Delhi’ is an expanded version of the Fourth Ramnath Goenka Memorial Lecture. ‘Of Mandarins and Masses’ is a hybrid of talks at St Stephen’s College, the Heritage Foundation, the University of Birmingham and the Atlantic Council. ‘The Nimzo Indian Defence’ is based on a lecture delivered in Singapore. ‘A Delayed Destiny’ combines discussions at the Delhi Policy Group, India Foundation and the India International Centre. ‘The Pacific Indian’ owes its articulation to three Indian Ocean Conferences organized by the India Foundation and one by the National Maritime Foundation. And ‘After the Virus’ builds on recent speeches starting with the Fifth Raisina Dialogue 2020, taking into account the impact of the pandemic.

To the organizations that provided a platform to formulate and express my thoughts, I am profoundly grateful. Audience responses were helpful in developing the argumentation. If propositions are sometimes deliberately sharpened, it is only with an intention to set minds at work. Global developments are clearly the overarching context for an exercise in which our national performance is assessed. The coronavirus epidemic is not only a reminder of this reality but also a harbinger of changes that the world will